

Hungary



A landlocked, ethnically diverse nation whose boundaries have been redrawn many times.

400s–600s CE The central Carpathian

basin is successively invaded by Huns and Avars, who are then conquered by Charlemagne in the late 700s.

800s CE The Magyars, a Finno-Ugric people from beyond the Ural mountains, move westward and conquer the region.

c.900 Semi-legendary prince Árpád, leader of the Magyars, founds a dynasty that lasts until 1301.

955 Magyars are heavily defeated by the Holy Roman Emperor Otto I at the Battle of Lechfeld. As part of the truce, Catholic missionaries arrive to convert the Magyars.

1001 Saint Stephen, who unifies the Magyars and completes Hungary's conversion to Christianity, is crowned the first King of Hungary. He rules until 1038.

1100 Hungarian rule now extends to include Slovakia, Ruthenia, and Transylvania.

1115–1420 Hungary and Venice clash 21 times for control over ports on the Adriatic.

1453 Ottoman Turkish assaults on Hungary increase after the fall of Constantinople, but in 1456 Janos Hunyadi, military regent of Hungary, breaks the siege of Belgrade and the Turks are kept at bay until 1521.

1458–90 The reign of Matthias Corvinus, second son of Janos Hunyadi, marks the golden age of Hungarian history. Mining of the country's gold, silver, and copper deposits makes it one of the richest countries in Europe, while success against the Turks brings it Bosnia (1461), Moldavia and Wallachia (1467), Moravia and Silesia (1478), and a large part of Austria itself by 1485.

1526 A peasant revolt allows the Ottoman Turks to enter the country and

win a massive victory at Mohács, where King Louis II is killed. Hungary loses its independence, which it does not regain until 1918. The Turks now control central Hungary (including Buda from 1541), while the west of the country submits to the Austrian Habsburgs. Transylvania is effectively ruled by the Ottomans.

1558 Tensions rise between Catholic "royal Hungary" and Transylvania, where freedom of worship for both Catholics and Lutherans is guaranteed by the Diet of Torda. These are especially high at the time of the 30 Years War (1618–48).

1606 Treaty of Zsitvatorok, designed to establish borders between Habsburg and Ottoman empires, fails to bring peace.

1699 Treaty of Karlowitz confirms the expulsion of the Turks from Hungary.

1703 In Transylvania Ferenc II Rakoczi leads a revolt, which is crushed by the Austrians, whose rule is confirmed in the Peace of Sztatmar of 1711.

1780 Emperor Josef II, who rules until 1790, attempts reforms, including the abolition of serfdom, but is thwarted by the Hungarian aristocracy. The Hungarian language is officially recognized. Hungarian literature and sciences contribute to a growing Hungarian nationalism.

1848 Revolution forces Emperor Ferdinand to make government accountable to parliament. Nationalist grievances lead to civil war. Ferdinand is persuaded to abdicate and is succeeded by his nephew, Franz-Josef.

1849 Franz-Josef is deposed and Lajos Kossuth, one of the leaders of the revolution, is declared provisional governor. Austria appeals to Russia for assistance. Some 200,000 Russian troops crush the revolt and Kossuth flees the country.

1861 The Hungarian Diet demands equality between Austria and Hungary.

1867 A dual monarchy of Austria–Hungary is created after Austria's defeat the previous year in a war against Prussia.

The two semi-independent states are held together by the emperor, who is king of Hungary, his court, common armed forces, and a common currency and customs union, but there is no single government and very different constitutions. Count Gyula Andrássy becomes the first Hungarian prime minister.

1914 Austria–Hungary provokes World War I after the murder of the Austrian Archduke Franz Ferdinand in Sarajevo leads it to declare war on Serbia; Germany comes to Austria–Hungary's support.

1918 Hungarian Republic is created as Austria–Hungary is defeated and falls apart at the end of World War I.

1919 Béla Kún leads a short-lived communist government. Romania intervenes militarily and hands power to Admiral Horthy, who acts as regent for the Hungarian claimant Charles, but refuses to hand over power to him when he returns to claim his throne in 1921.

1938–41 Hungary gains territory by the Vienna Award from Czechoslovakia, Yugoslavia, and Romania in return for supporting Nazi Germany.

1940 Hungary signs Tripartite Pact with Germany and its allies against the USSR, but remains out of the war.

1944 Nazi Germany preempts the Soviets by invading Hungary. The deportation of Jews and Roma to extermination camps begins. When the Soviet Red Army enters in October, Horthy is forced to resign.

1945 Liberation by the Red Army: a Soviet-formed provisional government is installed. Ferenc Nagy of the Smallholders Party becomes prime minister and tries to resist the communist takeover.

1947 Communists emerge as the largest party in the second post-war election.

1949 New constitution: Hungary formally becomes a People's Republic.

1950–51 First Secretary Mátyás Rákosi uses authoritarian powers to collectivize agriculture and industrialize the economy.

1953 Imre Nagy, Rákosi's rival, becomes premier and reduces political terror.

1955 Nagy deposed by Rákosi.

1956 Rákosi is forced out by the Soviets in an attempt to appease Hungarian unrest; student demonstrations demanding the withdrawal of Soviet troops and Nagy's return turn into a popular uprising. Nagy is reappointed premier and János Kádár becomes First Secretary. When Nagy announces Hungary will leave the Warsaw Pact, Soviet forces enter the country. About 25,000 are killed as Kádár takes over as premier.

1958 Nagy is executed.

1968 Kádár introduces "New Economic Mechanism" to bring market elements



Popular uprising

Soviet troops rolled into Budapest in November 1956 to put down an anti-Soviet uprising. The rebels seen here climbing onto a Soviet tank would soon be brutally rounded up and interned.

to socialism in order to liberalize communist rule gradually.

1986 Police suppress commemoration of the 1956 uprising. Democratic opposition demands that Kádár resign.

1987 Party reformers establish the Hungarian Democratic Forum (MDF) as a political movement.

1988 Kádár is ousted; environmental protests force the suspension of plans for Nagymaros Dam on the Danube.

1989 End of one-party state as parliament votes to allow independent parties. Posthumous rehabilitation of Nagy, who is given a state funeral. Round table talks between the government and opposition.

1990 József Antall's MDF wins multi-party elections decisively. Hungary moves from communism to free-market capitalism.

1991 Warsaw Pact is dissolved as the last Soviet troops leave Hungary.

1994 Former communist party, now the Hungarian Socialist Party (MSZP), wins general election under Gyula Horn. An austerity program prompts protests.

1998 Right-of-center coalition is formed.

1999 Joins NATO. Hungary's airspace is used in the NATO bombing of Yugoslavia during the Kosovo crisis.

2001 The Status Law granting special rights to ethnic Hungarians living mainly in Serbia and Romania causes tensions with its neighbors.

2004 Hungary joins the EU.

2009 Hungary receives \$25 billion economic package from EU and IMF following global economic crisis.

2010 The conservative opposition Fidesz party wins a landslide victory in parliamentary elections, gaining over two-thirds of the seats.

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HUNGARIAN KING (1443–90)

MATTHIAS CORVINUS

The son of military leader Janos Hunyadi, Matthias I was elected king of Hungary in 1458 in the face of rival claims from his uncle, Holy Roman Emperor Frederick III.

Matthias, nicknamed "Corvinus" after the raven on his emblem, did much to centralize the state during his reign, increasing taxes to pay for a standing army. He also championed the arts and sciences, which flourished in his court. Matthias successfully expanded Hungarian territory, taking many of Habsburg Frederick III's lands. After his death in 1490, however, all these gains were quickly lost.

